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Las malas

For Camila Sosa Villada, "all writing is a form of transvestism" (Bollig 131). Translating her 2019 work, *Las malas*, into English, I felt the translation must retain this defiance. Ben Bollig describes *Las malas* as a "novel-cum-memoir" (Bollig 114) with intentional status as "generically unstable" (115). The text goes between violent and magical realism, tying vulgarity to youthful innocence to describe the lives of a group of *travesti* sex workers in Córdoba's Parque Sarmiento.

As Juan Forn notes in his prologue, Sosa Villada's father warned her that a boy dressed as a woman was destined to end up dead in a ditch, nothing else. Instead, she turned that death sentence from society into high prose. When translating the prologue and opening excerpts of the novel, which describe some of Sosa Villada's later success and the lives of the *travestis* in the Park at night taking a turn with the discovery of an abandoned baby, my goal was to retain the inherent queerness of language, with long run on sentences interspersed with shorter ones, overall chaotic, but also coherent.

Similar to the need to retain *resentimiento* when translating Pedro Lemebel into English, I hoped to not sanitize the structure or language when translating into English. Translating *Las malas* is navigating the lines between monstrosity and normalcy, going back and forth. The

translation aims to connect the intersection of *travestis* monstrosity and tender care that serves as a theme on Sosa Villada's prose.

The most significant macro-level choice made to achieve this authenticity is the deliberate refusal to translate *travesti* into the English terms *transgender*, *transwoman*, *trans*, *transsexual*, or others. As Joseph M. Pierce notes, translating the idea of trans resistance in Latin America and the *travesti* identity into English as *transgender* "depoliticizes a violent history of social and economic marginalization" (307). In the context of Argentina, *travesti* also has a class-based consciousness. When there is "gender variance but not always gendered difference" with the use of *travesti*, we see that the class-based identity, tied with an identity on the streets, linking poverty, survival, and identity, would be lost if translated to *transgender*. By leaving *travesti* untranslated and keeping its heavy repetition in the English text, the translation aims to retain the close knit nature of the community, one that exists in defiance to the state. As Claudia Rodríguez says, "Para las travestis reales el estado no puede existir" (qtd. in Pierce 306). Retaining the word *travesti* acts as a linguistic barrier against assimilation, also forcing the English reader to accept characters on their own terms, acknowledging that state-sanctioned boundaries are meaningless for these women.

In refusing to assimilate, language is far from the only way. *Las travestis* operate at night, in a nocturnal form of the Park, outside the bounds of what is considered normal, daytime society. Parque Sarmiento is the stage for the survival sex work to connect to the magical realism. In translating this space outside daylight society, I tried to capture the Park similarly to how Sosa Villada did:

"A esa hora, el Parque es como un vientre de gozo, un recipiente de sexo sin vergüenza."

At that hour, the Park is like a womb of joy, a vessel of sex without shame.

Changing what would be the direct English cognate of "recipiente" as "recipient" to "vessel" was intentional; specifically, a vessel implies an object that holds something, contributing beyond existence. Furthermore, the text says the *travestis* "pasean su hechizo por la boca del lobo" (*they parade their spell through the mouth of the wolf*). Although a more palatable translation for this would translate "la boca del lobo" to the "lion's den," for the sentiment of mild danger, retaining "the mouth of the wolf" keeps the specific, fairytale-esque aesthetic built by Sosa Villada. Wolves are mythological, with a predatory weight aligning with how people perceive *travestis*. The magicalness of this space is further complicated by Laura's presence as "la única nacida mujer entre todas" (*the only one born a woman among all of them*). Here, Laura's cisgender body is a contrast against the artificial nature of *travestis* bodies, built from what could be found, whether mattresses or other materials.

To survive in the mouth of the wolf, the *travestis* lean into reject, using the othering directed at them and the fear of them as a mechanism for epistemological resistance. Pierce argues that the monster serves "as an insurrectional force that expands beyond the limits of embodied recognition" (306). In the text, the *travestis* are described with animalistic and supernatural traits. When La Tía Encarna calls out to the group after finding the baby, the original Spanish reads:

"Y se ponen alerta, la piel de gallina, los pelos erizados, las branquias abiertas, las fauces en tensión."

And they get alert, goosebumps, hair standing on end, gills open, jaws in tension.

I chose to keep this literal, mythological creature style anatomy in English, avoiding the urge to smooth it out with figurative language. To consider these monstrous traits as survival mechanisms rather than insults aligns with the book itself, and the autobiographical nature of this novel, despite its deviations from Sosa Villada's previous, non-fiction autobiography. It is exactly because of these monstrous traits that the *travestis*, approaching the baby as "una invasión de zombies" (*an invasion of zombies*), can hear the child crying more than any ordinary person. The monster blurs the line between binary good and bad, monster and slayer, hero and villain. In rescuing the child, La Tía Encarna becomes a mother with protective powers, rather than just marginalized status.

This protective power ties to the emotional aspect of the novel: *ternura* (tenderness). Bollig notes that Sosa Villada's work consistently contains tenderness which "can appear alongside sexual desire and intimacy, but also against a backdrop of, or even resulting from, violence and vulnerability" (114). The survival of the *travesti* requires navigating extreme danger and injury, with Sosa Villada's original text explaining the severity of La Tía Encarna's experiences:

"botines de policías y de clientes han jugado al fútbol con su cabeza y también con sus riñones

police boots and clients have played soccer with her head and also with her kidneys

I kept the brutal, visceral, tactile reality of this image in English to emphasize the way in which despite such extreme trauma, La Tía Encarna's body becomes the main source of tenderness

toward the abandoned baby. To understand the messiness of transmotherhood, something the text itself notes is socially taboo to the point of being considered "el delirio de La Tía Encarna," (*La Tía Encarna's delirium*), I leaned into the imagery coming from the rescue of the child from the bushes. Sosa Villada writes, "Parece una partera metiendo las manos dentro de la yegua para extraer al potrillo" (*She looks like a midwife, putting her hands inside a mare to extract the foal*). The pain of thorns on her skin, the dress covered in feces and blood is considered irrelevant quite quickly, but overlaps quite a bit with the process of giving birth. The translation here aims to ensure the beauty of motherhood still remains connected to the bloody realities that can cause it.

This addition to La Tía Encarna's physical trauma adds to another layer of the "generic instability" (Bollig 114): the translation of *travesti* time. In Sosa Villada's prose, the violence physically changes how time passes. When describing the matriarch, La Tía Encarna, for example, the original text notes: "La Tía Encarna tenía ciento setenta y ocho años" (La Tía Encarna was one hundred and seventy-eight years old). While this could be considered a hyperbole and treated as a metaphor to be translated, the choice to keep the original number came from the reasoning that trauma actively ages people. As something that is material and physical, I aligned with Juan Forn's approach "La vida travesti: un año de ellas equivale a siete años «normales»" (*one year of theirs is equal to seven "normal" years*). The *travesti* body, for the poverty, presence on the streets, night work, injections, physical violence, or danger, ages rapidly. I chose to translate time literally to keep the premise in the prologue, noting that by those calculations, that would make La Tía Encarna quite young, as is often the case in communities where there are risks of AIDS, and the other losses to violence in the *travesti* and trans communities.

In *Las malas*, chosen family's tenderness contrasts with the violence of biological family, a theme which required balance in translation. Sosa Villada compares the chosen family and La Tía Encarna's boarding house with the violent reality of her own birth, where her father threatened the doctor with a gun in order to force an operation. She uses the phrase "bajo amenaza" (*under a threat*) to describe her birth and "pasividad" (*passivity*) and "desgano" (*apathy*) to describe her mother. These words are not loving, nor tender. However, in the love shown in the *travesti* motherhood, the baby is protected by:

"Un resplandor verde enceguece a la muerte y la amenaza con vida"

A green glow blinds death and threatens it with life

In choosing to translate this more literally, I aimed to keep both the biological family and chosen family discussions to be around threats where one is a threat against someone to cause a birth while the other is a protective, spiritual glow that threatens death itself with life, contrasting with threatening death upon someone as her father had done.

The theme of chosen family and tenderness borne from rather than despite trauma is further shown in the introduction of the "Hombres Sin Cabeza" (Headless Men), African war refugees who enter romantic partnerships with the *travestis*. Bollig specifies that "the phrase 'headless man' is a way of referring to trauma, and how the men, wanting to forget past lives, 'sólo recordaban las cosas que habían sentido con la piel'" (125). In translating this to *the things they had felt with the skin*, I aimed to consider the skin as separate from theirs, just *the skin*, further tying to the ghostliness described of them. Keeping the sentence requires acknowledging the way in which the Headless Men, like the *travestis*, have been through trauma impacting their

identities and interactions. Specifically, Sosa Villada notes that the Headless Men find solace in the *travestis* because of the ability to share their trauma. In translating these sections, I aimed to keep a tone of respect, trying to contrast the other parts of the passage describing the social disgust and rumors spread about these couples with the nurturing, healing, accepting nature of their partnerships.

This focus on what is felt "with the skin" mirrors what Pierce describes as *travesti* epistemology, "accumulated through violence, joy, humor, desire, danger" (316). Here, in *Las malas*, the characters learn from the physical, shared history of their community. With the introduction of the Headless Men, we go into the gray area of "generic instability" which Bollig outlined (114). Sosa Villada has us go between mythology and trauma with the fantastical and the grotesque. Recognizing this, I chose not to smooth over magical aspects, trying to keep phrasing that seemed to extend past typical realism, such as the capitalization of Headless Men to give gravitas to their existence. In trying to translate this, I treated both the supernatural and violent passages with a similar tone, allowing for the reader to experience both through similar writing.

On the micro-level, translating *Las malas* meant embracing linguistic anomalies in order to retain other information that may be conveyed rather than smoothing them over to make a palatable translation for an English reader. For example, to keep the emphasis on senses and class consciousness, I kept unconventional phrasings of drug use:

"...papeles de cocaína visitan una a una todas las narices..."

...papers of cocaine visit all the noses one by one...

A more palatable translation might have said "they snorted lines of cocaine." However, in English, this erases a class marker implied by "papers," where those of upper-incomes in the United States within the literary and filmography spaces tend to consume cocaine in a non-paper format, such as from a mirror or a line. Given the implication of papers being something that is more hidden, more discrete, doable in public, I felt that the smoothness of lines was outweighed by the benefit of retaining class information and the personification of the drugs as visiting the *travestis*. Similarly, I kept the slightly unnatural run-on sentence structures from the original Spanish. When describing the flight from the Park with the baby, the syntax becomes strung together with commas. In the same vein, the experience selling ice cream to the man who invited Sosa Villada into a tent also remained one run-on sentence, the voice of a young person with racing thoughts and emotions, trying to make sense of the world, or the adults worried about the presence of police who also hold the hypervigilance of surviving immense violence. Keeping the chaotic syntax structure in these scenes keeps the reader continuing without a pause, similar to the way the events occur.

I also mirrored some of the literal forms of metaphors, another key feature in Sosa Villada's prose. For example, the phrase "el don de la transparencia" is kept as "the gift of transparency." Here, I intended it to be understood as a power, a way of remaining safe. However, in this being a gift, there comes the question of why it is a need and why it is used, answered roughly in the continuation of the passage and the idea that a visible *travesti* would inspire insults and violence, so transparency is a necessity for survival. This same power, which comes with a cost, is how the baby was hidden in a purse to be moved:

"--Adentro de la cartera. Cabe entero."

"Inside the purse. He fits entirely."

As Bollig notes, this serves both as a possible reality given the size of a baby of that age and the likely nod to Oscar Wilde's *The Importance of Being Earnest* (1895), the work of a bisexual author. In translating this more literally, I keep the dark comedy of the sentence, the quick quip explaining the baby can fit in a purse and also the nod to another work within the trans and queer communities.

Overall, the joy in reading this translated text lies heavily in its friction. While there are moments where the English reader may feel lost from the narrative, whether due to shocking juxtapositions of breastfeeding an abandoned infant while bleeding and unable to provide milk, the Headless Men's magical realism, or the clunky, literal rendering of local slang and bodily functions, this alienation is, in fact, the point. As Tim Chilcott demonstrated in his approach to translation without knowing Japanese, the translator must act deliberately, making the conductor role explicitly part of the process. In *Las malas*, the text should not feel cozy or assimilated. The experiences of *travesti* are their own and their community, their class, their language, their bodies, and their words should not erase who they are, what they have suffered, and how they show care. In keeping the language wild with monstrous elements, the translation attempts to keep Camila Sosa Villada's project going: proving poetry can take the form of a *travesti* body.

Bibliography

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